

LAUSD scores improve but also fall short

District fares better than the state as a whole but misses its own four-year targets.

By Howard Blume

The Los Angeles school district is falling short of meeting school board-approved academic goals set four years ago, but students continue to improve faster on key academic measurements than the state as a whole, based on data released last week.

A presentation to the Board of Education during a five-hour meeting kicked off a deeper evaluation as leaders prepare the district's next strategic plan, which would take effect in July.

The data served as a reality check amid acclaim that the Los Angeles Unified School District has heaped on itself and also has received from state officials applauding the district's positive education news.

By the yardstick of its own goals, the nation's second-largest school system is likely to fall short by nearly every parameter. Reading and math scores are below targets even though they are incrementally better compared with six years ago. Ditto for the percentage of graduates who qualify to apply to Cal State and the University of California, even though the percentage increase in this area is strong.

L.A. Unified's adoption of a strategic plan is borrowed from the corporate world and offers a way for the public to see whether the district's own benchmarks are being met.

One notable milestone for L.A. Unified is that Supt. Alberto Carvalho reached the end of the four-year plan he crafted — given the high turnover and shrinking tenure of superintendents nationwide.

"Have we reached everything we promised we would reach?" Carvalho said in opening remarks at the meeting. "Absolutely not." [See L.A. Unified, A8]



Photographs by SANDY HUFFAKER For The Times

"IT IS easier to build in San Diego ... because of its legal structure, political culture and defined processes," said Kevin Shannon, a real estate industry insider.

San Diego has an edge over L.A. on apartments

The city is friendlier toward developers, experts say

By Roger Vincent

As Los Angeles grapples with a housing shortage, it could learn from San Diego, which has proved better at convincing construction companies to build more.

The city is more welcoming to developers, industry insiders say, with fewer regulations and fees, better planning and less rent control.

"It is easier to build in San Diego over Los Angeles because of its legal structure, political culture and defined processes," said Kevin Shannon, co-head of capital markets at real estate brokerage Newmark, which is overseeing the sale of a sprawling development

site in San Diego that is zoned to have thousands of apartments.

The result: As of last quarter, the number of new apartments under construction in San Diego County rose 10% from three years earlier, CoStar data show. New apartment construction in Los Angeles County tumbled 33% over the same period, hitting an 11-year low in the three months through December. San Diego is expanding its apartment pool at nearly twice the rate of L.A. and other major city clusters in the state.

L.A.'s vacancy rate is

among the lowest in the country and rental rates are among the highest nationwide. Still, the supply of fresh rental units, which make up the bulk of new housing in Los Angeles, is thinning out despite robust demand.

Although local lawmakers create regulations to protect renters and keep rents down, hoping to combat homelessness, developers and economists warn that the wrong regulations often can add to the cost of building and maintaining apartments, making it hard to make a profit on new and [See Apartments, A8]

Trump's first year back: 11 stunning moves

Year 1 of second term full of unprecedented actions, some in direct conflict with his vows.

By Kevin Rector

During his first term, President Trump was both praised and condemned for being wildly unpredictable, pushing boundaries and disregarding long-standing norms in Washington.

During the 2024 presidential campaign, then-Vice President Kamala Harris, Trump's opponent, spoke directly to his volatile leadership style in her final pitch to voters, saying their choice would determine "whether we have a country rooted in freedom for every American or ruled by chaos and division."

Americans returned Trump to the White House. And in the year since, they have watched Trump once again take stunning and unprecedented action — sometimes in line with his campaign promises, other times in direct conflict with them.

Deploying troops, immigration forces

During his campaign, Trump promised to launch the "largest deportation operation in American history." The rollout has been tense as masked agents with Immigration and Customs Enforcement, Customs and Border Protection and other agencies have swarmed American cities and detained large numbers of people — including many with no criminal convictions and some who are U.S. citizens.

The agents' use of aggressive tactics and deadly force, including in the recent fatal shooting of Renee Nicole Good by an ICE agent in Minnesota, has sparked protests and concern among local leaders and members of Congress.

Trump responded to some protests by ordering National Guard troops into cities, including Los Angeles. He also sent Marines into L.A. Those deployments were challenged in court, and after a loss in the Supreme Court, Trump ended them. However, he has since threatened to send [See Trump, A6]



GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times

LOS ANGELES city crews are working seven days a week to tackle a surge of complaints about potholes.

After record rains, more rocky roads

Thousands of new potholes in L.A. could be costly hazards for drivers and the city.

By Alex Wigglesworth

Jin Shin has come across some monster potholes over the last couple of weeks, including one in Koreatown that rattled his car with a sickening thump and another near the airport where its depth was obscured by water.

"The car just tilted in way, way deep," said the 31-year-old, who runs the TikTok account Dash Cam of L.A. Luckily, Shin was going slow enough that he didn't sustain any damage — this time. He learned his lesson about a decade ago when a pothole blew out one of his shocks near an entrance to the 2 Freeway, costing him about \$2,500 to repair.

Born and raised in L.A., Shin said that learning to negotiate pockmarked pavement is part of every Angeleno's driving education. "Basically, we learn a lesson after our cars break down," he said. "We remember where the potholes are on each street. That's our way of survival."

With more than 14 inches of rain falling on downtown L.A. since October — roughly 99% of what the city typically sees during the entire rainy season that ends in March — there have been a lot of new potholes for drivers to map out on their daily commutes.

Officials can't say exactly how many potholes there are out there — just the number of those that have been reported. But the record rains have left the region's roads awash in them, and crews are trying to keep up. The rocky conditions of roads have become a hot [See Potholes, A6]

Disney succession plan enters crunch time

Walt Disney Co. can ill afford another succession implosion.

The last time Chief Executive Bob Iger handed over the reins, the plan backfired, executives revolted, his replacement got bounced, and Iger returned to lead the storied entertainment giant for four more years.

Iger will close out his two-decade tenure at Disney at the end of this year when his contract expires. The board is preparing to make a pivotal leadership move at a perilous time for the industry.

This time, Disney entrusted a take-charge outsider to oversee its CEO transition, which is expected to unfold in the coming weeks.

James P. Gorman, former head of Morgan Stanley, became Disney's chairman a year ago with succession at the top of his

Next CEO must fortify streaming service and huge franchises, keep parks and cruises growing while harnessing AI

By Meg James

to-do list. The 67-year-old Australian native comes with strong opinions and sterling credentials: He helped stabilize, then revitalize the Wall Street bank during his 14 years in the C-suite, retiring in December 2024 after orchestrating a seamless baton pass.

"I don't know that there's anyone who could have navigated these kinds of leadership transitions better than James," Wharton School Dean Erika H. James said in an interview. "He's not afraid to do the hard things."

Disney has kept a lid on its deliberations. The company declined to make Gorman available for this story.

Four internal candidates have been vying for the job, and many believe the parks boss, Josh D'Amato, is the likely successor. [See Disney, A12]

Trump ties stance on Greenland to his Nobel Peace Prize grievance

By Aamer Madhani, Geir Moulson and Jill Lawless

LONDON — President Trump linked his aggressive stance on Greenland to last year's decision not to award him the Nobel Peace Prize, telling Norway's prime minister that he no longer felt "an obligation to think purely of Peace," in a text message released on Monday.

Trump's message to Jonas Gahr Store appears to

ratchet up a standoff between Washington and its closest allies over his threats to take over Greenland, a self-governing territory of NATO member Denmark. On Saturday, Trump announced a 10% import tax starting in February on goods from eight nations that have rallied around Denmark and Greenland, including Norway.

Those countries issued a forceful rebuke.

Many longtime allies of the U.S. remained resolute that Greenland was not for

sale but encouraged Washington to discuss solutions. In a statement on social media, the European Union's foreign policy chief, Kaja Kallas, said the bloc had "no interest to pick a fight" but would "hold our ground."

The White House has not ruled out taking control of the strategic Arctic island by force. Asked whether Trump could invade Greenland, Danish Foreign Minister Lars Lokke Rasmussen said Monday that "you can't leave anything out until the [See Greenland, A4]



GINA FERRAZZI Los Angeles Times

A DEATH IN ICE CUSTODY

Mourners attend a memorial for Luis Beltrán Yanez-Cruz, 68, in Coachella. His family says he needed care and wants an inquiry. CALIFORNIA, B1

Rams keep their cool and advance

They overcome heroics by Bears and prevail on kick in snowy Chicago to reach the NFC title game. SPORTS, B10

Funding cuts hit defense firms

L.A.-area startups are seeking alternatives as a federal program comes under fire for desired reforms. BUSINESS, A10

Weather

Lots of sun. L.A. Basin: 75/51. B6



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